

Child Abuse in Pakistan: Parental Accountability in the Context of Systemic Failures

Child abuse in Pakistan has reached catastrophic proportions, with 4,213 reported cases in 2023 alone—an average of 11 children abused daily, including infants as young as 0–5 years. These figures, compiled by NGOs like Sahil and the National Commission for Human Rights (NCHR), expose a crisis where 53% of victims are girls and 47% boys, predominantly targeted by acquaintances, relatives, or family members. While systemic gaps in governance and poverty exacerbate vulnerabilities, the primary responsibility for child protection lies with parents, who control the immediate environments where most abuse occurs. This essay argues that parents bear the foremost duty to safeguard children, while the government's role remains critical in addressing structural inequalities and enforcing protective frameworks.

Legal and Cultural Foundations of Parental Responsibility

Under Pakistani law, parents are legally obligated to protect children from harm. The Punjab Destitute and Neglected Children Act (2007) explicitly criminalizes parental negligence, stating that any person with “actual charge of or control over a child” who willfully assaults, neglects, or fails to provide necessities faces up to three years imprisonment. These provisions align with Islamic principles and cultural norms emphasizing familial duty. However, enforcement remains inconsistent, as seen in cases where parents abandon children to NGOs like Edhi due to economic distress. Despite inflation and unemployment, the law does not absolve parents of responsibility; instead, it mandates proactive measures to seek assistance. For instance, the Sindh Legal Advisory Call Center (SLACC) reported numerous inquiries from parents struggling to care for children during the COVID-19 pandemic, highlighting both their recognition of duty and systemic inadequacies in support. Legal frameworks thus place the onus on parents to utilize available resources—a mandate often unfulfilled, contributing to preventable cases of neglect.

Proximity and Perpetration: The Home as a Site of Danger

Over 75% of child sexual abuse cases in Punjab and 13% in Sindh involve perpetrators known to the victim, including family members. This pattern underscores parents' failure to secure home environments. Research by Sahil reveals that children aged 6–15—the most vulnerable group—are frequently abused by relatives or acquaintances during unsupervised interactions. Parents' authority over household dynamics positions them as frontline protectors, yet many disregard red flags or normalize exploitative behaviors. For example, corporal punishment remains widespread, despite evidence linking physical discipline to escalated abuse. The PDNC Act prohibits excessive punishment, but cultural acceptance of violence as “discipline” perpetuates harm. Parents' reluctance to challenge societal norms—or report abuse within extended families—enables perpetrators, as seen in cases where incestuous abuse is concealed to protect familial honor. Without parental vigilance, even robust legal frameworks cannot prevent atrocities occurring behind closed doors.

Economic Hardship and Parental Decision-Making

Poverty is a significant risk factor, with 33% of abuse cases linked to economic shocks. However, financial strain does not absolve parental responsibility. The Ministry of Human Rights notes that child labor—a precursor to abuse—often stems from parental decisions to send children into hazardous work environments. While inflation and unemployment exacerbate desperation, parents retain agency to seek alternatives. Organizations like Sahil and government helplines (e.g., 1099) provide crisis support, yet underutilization persists. For instance, the Aitzaz Hasan Child Protection Institute in Islamabad offers rehabilitation for street children, but many families remain unaware of such resources. Parental failure to access these services reflects a broader cultural tendency to prioritize immediate economic survival over long-term child welfare—a trade-off that perpetuates cycles of exploitation.

Counterarguments: Systemic Neglect and Government Accountability

Advocates of government accountability rightly highlight systemic failures. Punjab's 75% share of reported abuse cases correlates with its population density but also reveals disparities in provincial child protection infrastructures. Balochistan and Gilgit-Baltistan, with minimal reporting, likely suffer from underresourced institutions rather than lower incidence. The NCHR condemns the absence of a national action plan, leaving policies fragmented across provinces. Furthermore, state employees—including law enforcement—are implicated in abuse, with Human Rights Watch documenting violence by police and orphanage staff. These institutional failures create environments where abuse thrives unchecked.

However, systemic issues do not negate parental duty. Even in impoverished communities, many families resist exploiting children, demonstrating that cultural values and individual choices mediate economic pressures. The government's role is to amplify these positive norms through policies like childcare subsidies and paid family leave, which reduce stressors driving neglect. Conversely, parental complacency in reporting abuse—or complicity in child marriages for financial gain—underscores the need for cultural shifts led by families themselves.

Conclusion: Integrated Solutions for a Collective Crisis

Addressing child abuse in Pakistan requires recognizing shared responsibility. Parents must reject harmful traditions, monitor home environments, and actively seek support. Concurrently, the government should implement a national action plan unifying provincial efforts, expand child protection institutes, and enforce laws criminalizing negligence. Economically, initiatives like the Benazir Income Support Program could be tailored to incentivize school enrollment over child labor. Communities, too, must challenge stigmatization of abuse survivors to encourage reporting.

As Sahil's data shows, progress is possible: concerted advocacy has increased reporting rates by 33% since 2022, indicating growing awareness. By merging parental vigilance with systemic reform, Pakistan can transform its “cruel numbers” into a legacy of protection.